STUDY GUIDE & ACTIVITY BOOK

ٱلْبَلَد

Surah Al-Balad

The City • The Steep Path of Goodness

SURAH 90 | 20 AYAHS



Big question: Allah sees everything we do. What will you do with your time, your money, and your gifts?

Name: _____ Age 10–12

START HERE

Surah at a glance

90 of 114	20	Makkah	"The City"
Number	Ayahs	Revealed	Name means

The shape of the surah

1–3	4–7	8–10	11–17	18–20
The oath	Life is a test	Allah's gifts	The steep path	Two outcomes

The big idea. Life is full of challenges, and Allah has given every human the ability to tell right from wrong. The surah asks: will you brag and waste, or take the hard, rewarding path of helping others?

Why is it called Al-Balad? The first two ayahs swear by *this city*, Makkah, even though the Prophet (peace be upon him) was being treated badly there.

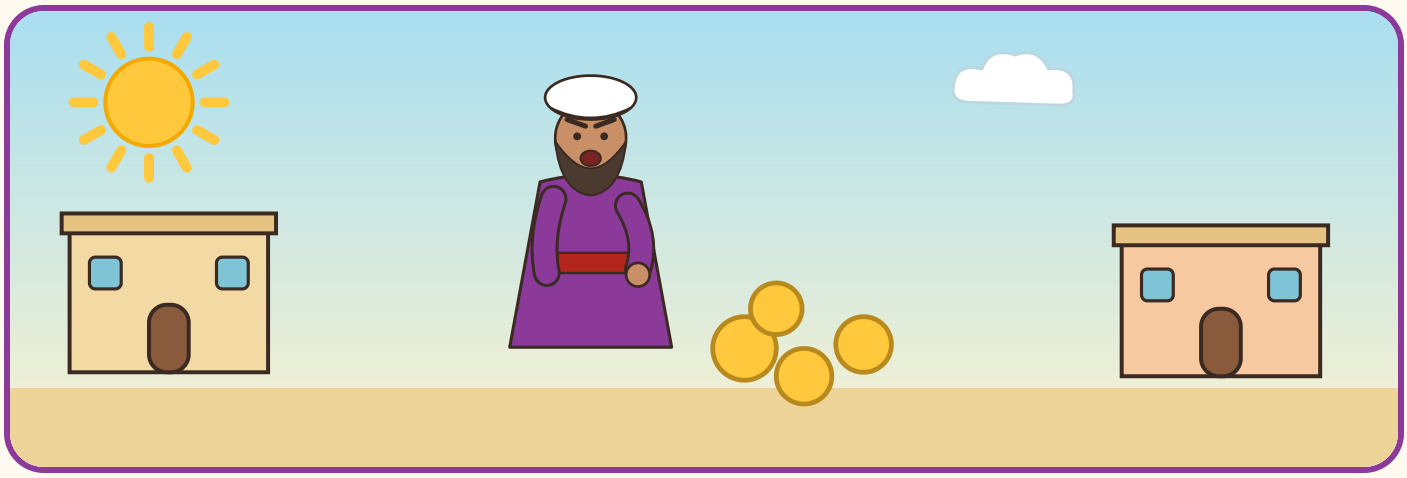
What to look for as you read

- Allah tests people in different ways. Some are tested with hardship, and some with good health and wealth, to see who is **thankful**.
- Everyone has the gift of knowing right from wrong. Those who use it well are promised a great reward. Those who choose evil are warned.
- The "steep path" is not about being famous or rich. It is about **faith, patience, and kindness** shown through real actions.

Learning points adapted from *The Clear Quran for Kids*.

THE STORY BEHIND IT

The man who thought money made him mighty



In Makkah lived an idol-worshipper named **Al-Ashadd**. He was so strong that even ten men could not move him from his place. He bragged about his power, and he bragged about how much money he had *wasted* on turning people away from Islam.

This passage came to remind him, and people like him, that Allah is the Most Powerful. It would have been far better if they had spent that money on helping people in need.

At the same time, the Prophet (peace be upon him) was being mistreated in Makkah. Ayah 2 mentions this: Allah swears by the city *even though* its people were abusing His messenger there.

Think about it

1. Why do you think the man believed that money and strength made him safe?
2. What question does ayah 7 ask him?
3. How can wealth be a test, and not only a gift?

Reported by Imam At-Tabari, as told in *The Clear Quran for Kids*.

Ayahs 1–5: The city, the test, and the bragger

Start with: Bismillah-ir-Rahman-ir-Raheem

1

لَا أُقْسِمُ بِهَٰذَا ٱلْبَلَدِ

learned

I swear by this city (of Makkah)—

Learn: Allah swears by Makkah, the city of the Ka'bah and of the Prophet. Swearing by something in the Quran tells us it is important and worth our attention.

2

وَأَنتَ حِلٌّۢ بِهَٰذَا ٱلْبَلَدِ

learned

even though you (O Prophet) are being abused in this city—

Learn: The Prophet was being mistreated in Makkah. Allah mentions this to comfort him: even an honored place can be a place of hardship, and Allah knows exactly what His servants face.

3

وَوَالِدٍ وَمَا وَلَدَ

learned

and by every parent and (their) child!

Learn: Some scholars explain "parent and child" as Adam and his descendants, and others as every parent and child. Either way, it points to the whole human family.

4

لَقَدْ خَلَقْنَا ٱلْإِنسَٰنَ فِى كَبَدٍ

learned

We have certainly created humankind to go from one challenge to another.

Learn: The word kabad means struggle. Life brings many challenges: childbirth, teething, sickness, studying, poverty, work, travelling, raising children, old age, death, and judgment. Allah tests some with hardship and some with health and wealth, to see who is thankful.

5

أَيَحْسَبُ أَن لَّن يَقْدِرَ عَلَيْهِ أَحَدٌ

learned

Now, does that person think that no one has power over him,

Learn: This is about arrogance. The man thought no one could overpower him because he was so strong. The surah reminds us that Allah has power over everyone, even the strongest.

Ayahs 6–10: Allah sees, and Allah gives

6 يَقُولُ أَهْلَكْتُ مَالًا لُّبَدًا ☐ learned

bragging, "I have wasted tons of money!"?

Learn: The word lubad means piled up, a huge heap. He boasted about spending piles of money to oppose Islam. Showing off and wasting money is a mistake. Wealth is a test, and it is meant to help people.

7 أَيَحْسَبُ أَن لَّمْ يَرَهُۥٓ أَحَدٌ ☐ learned

Does he think that no one sees him?

Learn: Allah asks this question to teach that nothing is hidden. We are always seen and always accountable, even when no one else is watching.

8 أَلَمْ نَجْعَل لَّهُۥ عَيْنَيْنِ ☐ learned

Have We not given him two eyes,

Learn: Sight is a gift. Allah begins the list of blessings with the eyes. These gifts are evidence that we are responsible for how we use them.

9 وَلِسَانًا وَشَفَتَيْنِ ☐ learned

a tongue, and two lips;

Learn: Speech is a gift too. Our tongue and lips can speak truth, kindness and reminders of goodness, or they can hurt. Each of us decides how to use them.

10 وَهَدَيْنَٰهُ ٱلنَّجْدَيْنِ ☐ learned

and shown him the two ways (of right and wrong)?

Learn: The "two ways" are the path of good and the path of wrong. Everyone has the ability to tell them apart and the freedom to choose, so we are responsible for our choices.

Ayahs 11–15: The steep path begins

11 فَلَا ٱقْتَحَمَ ٱلْعَقَبَةَ ☐ learned

If only he had tried the challenging path (of goodness) instead!

Learn: The word for "tried" means to push into something hard. The steep path (*'aqabah*) is a hard climb, like going uphill. It is the better way to use our wealth, time and strength.

12 وَمَآ أَدْرَىٰكَ مَا ٱلْعَقَبَةُ ☐ learned

And what will make you realize what "trying" the challenging path is?

Learn: Allah asks this question to make us curious and ready to listen. It tells us the steep path is something big that we must understand, and the next ayahs explain it.

13 فَكُّ رَقَبَةٍ ☐ learned

It is to free a slave,

Learn: In the past this meant freeing a person from slavery, which was a great act in Islam. Today it still reminds us to help people out of hardship and to care about others' freedom and dignity.

14 أَوْ إِطْعَٰمٌ فِي يَوْمٍ ذِي مَسْغَبَةٍ ☐ learned

or to give food in times of hunger

Learn: Feeding someone in time of hunger is feeding them when they need it most. This also connects to wasting food: if we waste, we forget those who do not have enough.

15 يَتِيمًا ذَا مَقْرَبَةٍ ☐ learned

to an orphaned relative

Learn: Helping an orphan who is also a relative has a double value: caring for a child who lost a parent, and keeping family ties strong. Look after the people closest to you.

Ayahs 16–20: Faith, kindness, and two outcomes

16 أَوْ مِسْكِينًا ذَا مَتْرَبَةٍ ☐ learned

or to a poor person badly in need,

Learn: The wording describes someone in such need that they are, in effect, in the dust. This ayah teaches that anyone who is badly in need deserves our help, whoever they are.

17 ثُمَّ كَانَ مِنَ ٱلَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَتَوَاصَوْا بِٱلصَّبْرِ وَتَوَاصَوْا بِٱلْمَرْحَمَةِ ☐ learned

and—above all—to be one of those who have faith and encourage each other to be patient and encourage each other to be kind.

Learn: Notice "above all." Good deeds are strongest when they come from faith. Believers also remind each other to be patient (sabr) and compassionate (marhamah), so we climb together as a community.

18 أُولَٰئِكَ أَصْحَابُ ٱلْمَيْمَنَةِ ☐ learned

These are the people of the right.

Learn: "The right" means the people who succeed and are honored by Allah. They are those who believed, did good, and encouraged others to be patient and kind.

19 وَٱلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بِآيَاتِنَا هُمْ أَصْحَابُ ٱلْمَشْأَمَةِ ☐ learned

As for those who deny Our signs, they are the people of the left.

Learn: The "left" are those who deny Allah's signs, in the Quran and in the world around us. The surah says this plainly: refusing the truth leads to a sad ending.

20 عَلَيْهِمْ نَارٌ مُؤْصَدَةٌ ☐ learned

The Fire will be shut over them.

Learn: Allah ends with a serious warning. "Shut over them" means sealed in, with no escape. It reminds us that our choices in this life matter, and it is wise to choose the steep path now.

WORD STUDY

Ten key words and their roots

Most Arabic words grow from a three-letter **root**. Spotting roots helps you remember words and see connections.

Word	Sounds like	Meaning	Root	Ayah
بَلَد	**ba-lad**	city, land	ب ل د	1, 2
كَبَد	**ka-bad**	hardship, struggle	ك ب د	4
لِسَان	**li-saan**	tongue	ل س ن	9
شَفَة	**sha-fah**	lip	ش ف ه	9
عَقَبَة	**'a-qa-bah**	steep mountain path	ع ق ب	11, 12
رَقَبَة	**ra-qa-bah**	neck; a person in bondage	ر ق ب	13
مَسْغَبَة	**mas-gha-bah**	hunger, famine	س غ ب	14
يَتِيم	**ya-teem**	orphan	ي ت م	15
صَبْر	**sabr**	patience, steadiness	ص ب ر	17
مَرْحَمَة	**mar-ha-mah**	compassion, kindness	ر ح م	17

Your turn: Find رَقَبَة and عَقَبَة in the surah. They sound alike but have different roots. Which one means a person who needs freeing, and which one is the steep path?

Answer: _____

GOING DEEPER

Three big ideas

1. Life is a series of challenges (ayah 4)

The word *kabad* means struggle. Humans go from one challenge to the next. Some are tested with hardship, and some with health and wealth, to see who is thankful.

childbirth · teething · sickness · studying · poverty · work · travelling · raising children · old age · death · judgment

Discuss: Which of these challenges have you already faced? Which teach us to rely on Allah?

2. Allah sees, and we are accountable (ayahs 5–10)

The bragger asks if anyone sees him. Allah replies by listing what He gave: two eyes, a tongue, two lips, and the knowledge of two ways. Gifts bring responsibility.

Discuss: How should "Allah sees me" change what you do online, at school, and when you are alone?

3. The steep path is serving people (ayahs 11–17)

It is called steep because it takes effort and goes against comfort. The surah lists real actions: freeing people, feeding the hungry, supporting a relative who is an orphan, and helping those badly in need. Then comes the community: believing, and encouraging each other to patience and compassion.

Discuss: Why does the surah say "and—above all" before faith and encouragement? Why can't we climb alone?

Two outcomes (18–20): the "people of the right" who believe and do good, and those who deny Allah's signs. The surah ends with a serious warning, so our choices matter.

ACTIVITY 1 • SORT IT OUT

Two paths

Path A
Bragging and wasting

Path B
The steep path of goodness

Circle **A** or **B** for each behavior.

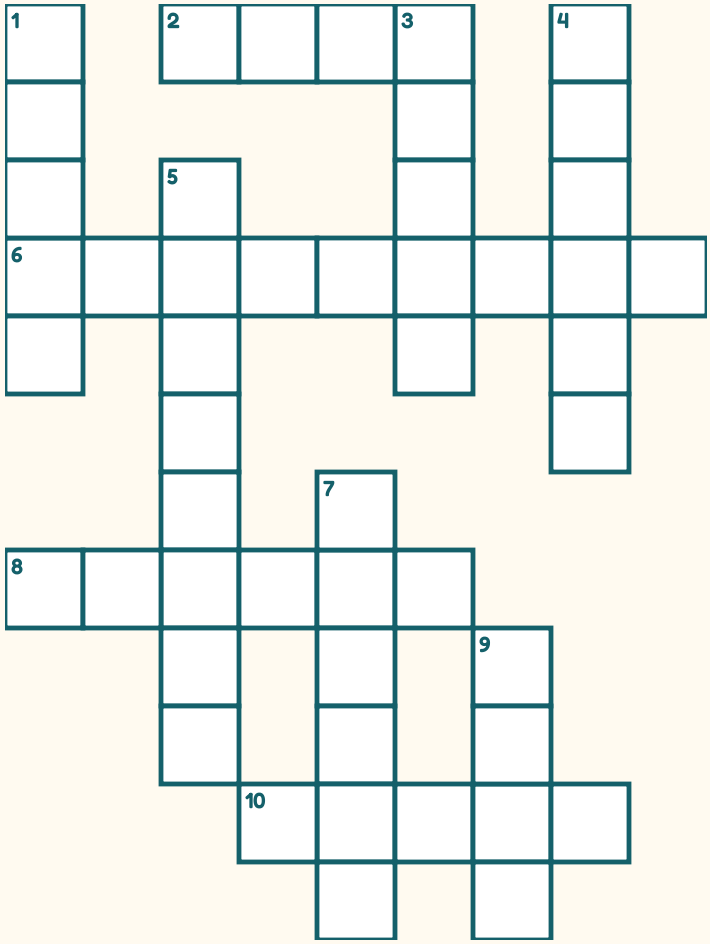
1. Spends money just to show off — A B
2. Gives food to someone who is hungry — A B
3. Thinks nobody can see what he does — A B
4. Supports a relative who lost a parent — A B
5. Reminds friends to be patient — A B
6. Brags, “I wasted so much money!” — A B
7. Throws away half his food — A B
8. Believes and keeps doing good — A B
9. Uses his tongue for kind words — A B
10. Ignores people who need help — A B

Finish this sentence: *This week I will choose Path B by*

_____

ACTIVITY 2 • CROSSWORD

Surah Al-Balad crossword



Across →

2. Allah gave us two of these (ayah 8) (4)

6. Humans are created to face one after another (ayah 4) (9)

8. Feed people in times of ___ (ayah 14) (6)

10. Belief in Allah that comes before good deeds (5)

Down ↓

1. Compassion; believers encourage each other to it (5)

3. Like the challenging hill in the surah (5)

4. Allah gave us two lips and a ___ (6)

5. Staying calm and not giving up (ayah 17) (8)

7. A child who has lost a parent (6)

9. Makkah is the ___ Allah swears by (4)

ACTIVITY 3 • READ AND RECALL

Fill in the missing Arabic word

Choose the word from the bank that completes each ayah. Check yourself with the surah pages.

يَتِيمًا | مُّؤْصَدَةٌ | مِسْكِينًا | عَيْنَيْنِ | رَقَبَةٍ | شَفَتَيْنِ

1

أَلَمْ نَجْعَل لَّهُ _____

Have We not given him two ____

2

وَلِسَانًا وَ_____

a tongue and two ____

3

فَكُّ _____

to free a ____ (person in bondage)

4

_____ ذَا مَقْرَبَةٍ

an ____ relative

5

أَوْ _____ ذَا مَتْرَبَةٍ

a ____ person badly in need

6

عَلَيْهِمْ نَارٌ _____

the Fire will be ____ over them

ACTIVITY 4 • ORDER AND DECODE

Put the ayahs in order

These four ayahs are mixed up. Write **1–4** in the circles to show their order in the surah.

◯	وَلِسَانًا وَشَفَتَيْنِ
◯	فَلَا ٱقْتَحَمَ ٱلْعَقَبَةَ
◯	أَلَمْ نَجْعَل لَّهُۥ عَيْنَيْنِ
◯	وَهَدَيْنَٰهُ ٱلنَّجْدَيْنِ

Decode the secret messages

Each message is shifted 3 letters. Use the key: the top letter is real, the red letter is what you see.

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M	N	O	P
N	**O**	**P**	**Q**	**R**	**S**	**T**	**U**	**V**	**W**	**X**	**Y**	**Z**
Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z	A	B	C

DOODK VHHV HYHUBWKLQJ

IHHG WKH KXQJUB

EH SDWLHQW DQG NLQG

ACTIVITY 5 • REAL LIFE

Omar's dream and your waste audit



Omar dreamed that his dinner took him to court. The rice, peppers, olive oil and fish each complained: they had traveled thousands of miles, with many people farming, picking, driving, cooking and serving, and then half of the meal went into the garbage. Omar said sorry and promised to finish his food or share it with someone in need.

The surah connection: the bragger boasted about wasting money. Waste is a habit we can notice and change.

Seven-day audit: color a circle each day you did it

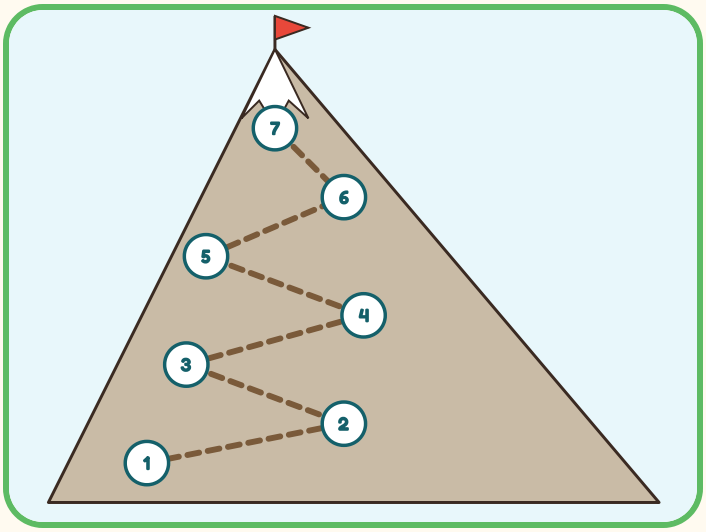
	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
I finished my food or shared it	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
I used water carefully	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
I turned off lights I did not need	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
I used my time well (no mindless scrolling)	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
I bought only what I needed	○	○	○	○	○	○	○

My biggest area of waste was _____. Next week I will _____.

ACTIVITY 6 • 7-DAY CHALLENGE

Climb the steep path

Do one step each day. Color its circle on the mountain when you finish. Reach the flag by day 7!



1. **Share food.** Give some of your food or snack to someone who needs it.
2. **Kind words only.** Use your tongue only for kind, true words all day.
3. **No waste day.** Finish your food. Save water and lights.
4. **Help unasked.** Do a job at home or school before anyone asks.
5. **Stay patient.** When something annoys you, pause, breathe, and stay calm.
6. **Reach out.** Call, visit, or help a relative, neighbor, or give to charity.
7. **Encourage a friend.** Kindly remind a friend to be patient or do good.

Which step was hardest? Why?

ACTIVITY 7 • MAKE IT REAL

My steep-path service project

The surah lists real actions: feed the hungry, support an orphaned relative, help people in need. Plan one small project you can really do, with a grown-up's help.

1 Who needs help near me? (family, neighbor, school, community)

2 What can I give?

- ☐ Food
- ☐ Time
- ☐ Skills
- ☐ Kind words
- ☐ Money / donation
- ☐ Reminders / encouragement

3 My plan: three small steps

4 When will I do it, and who will help me?

5 How will I know it worked? What will I do next?

Start small. A small steady kindness is better than a big plan that never happens.

REFLECT

Journal: what does this surah ask of me?

Write honestly. Nobody has to read it but you.

1 **Think of a challenge you have faced. What did it teach you about yourself, and about relying on Allah?**

2 **If Allah sees everything, how should that change the way you act when no one is watching?**

3 **Which part of the "steep path" is hardest for you? What makes it hard, and what could help you do it anyway?**

CHECK YOURSELF

Quiz: how much do you remember?

Circle the best answer. Question 10 is open-ended.

1. What does "Al-Balad" mean?

A. The Night
B. The City
C. The Path
D. The Test

2. Which city does Allah swear by in this surah?

A. Madinah
B. Jerusalem
C. Makkah
D. Taif

3. According to ayah 4, humans are created to…

A. live without worries
B. go from one challenge to another
C. collect wealth
D. avoid all effort

4. What did the man in the story brag about?

A. His knowledge
B. His power and the money he wasted
C. His family
D. His travels

5. Which gifts does Allah list in ayahs 8–9?

A. Eyes, a tongue and two lips
B. Wealth and land
C. Strength and speed
D. Children and fame

6. What does Allah show us in ayah 10?

A. Where treasure is hidden
B. The two ways, right and wrong
C. The future
D. The oceans

7. Which is NOT part of the steep path?

A. Feeding the hungry
B. Helping an orphaned relative
C. Bragging about spending
D. Encouraging patience

8. What do believers encourage each other to do (ayah 17)?

A. Be patient and kind
B. Be rich and famous
C. Travel often
D. Win arguments

9. The "people of the right" are those who…

A. live in big cities
B. believe and do good
C. brag the loudest
D. avoid everyone

10. Name one way to follow this surah in your own life this week.

COMMIT

My steep-path pledge

With the help of Allah, I will use my **eyes** to see what is good, my **tongue** to speak kindly, and my **lips** to remind others of what is right. This month I will:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

_____ Signed

_____ Date

For parents and teachers: answer key

Quiz: 1B • 2C • 3B • 4B • 5A • 6B • 7C • 8A • 9B. Q10 is open-ended.
Two paths: A = 1, 3, 6, 7, 10. B = 2, 4, 5, 8, 9.
Fill the Arabic word: 1 عَيْنَيْنِ. • 2 شَفَتَيْنِ • 3 رَقَبَةٍ • 4 يَتِيمًا • 5 مِسْكِينًا • 6 مُّؤْصَدَةٌ
Ayah order: the circles, top to bottom, should read 2, 4, 1, 3. **Ciphers:** ALLAH SEES EVERYTHING, FEED THE HUNGRY, BE PATIENT AND KIND.
Crossword words: CHALLENGE, PATIENCE, TONGUE, HUNGRY, ORPHAN, MERCY, FAITH, STEEP, CITY, EYES.
Word study: رَقَبَة is the person in bondage (ayah 13); عَقَبَة is the steep path (ayahs 11–12).

Content adapted from *The Clear Quran for Kids*. Please have the Arabic text checked by a qualified reader.